



CYCLE OF ANXIETY


Lesley Shearer
Counselling

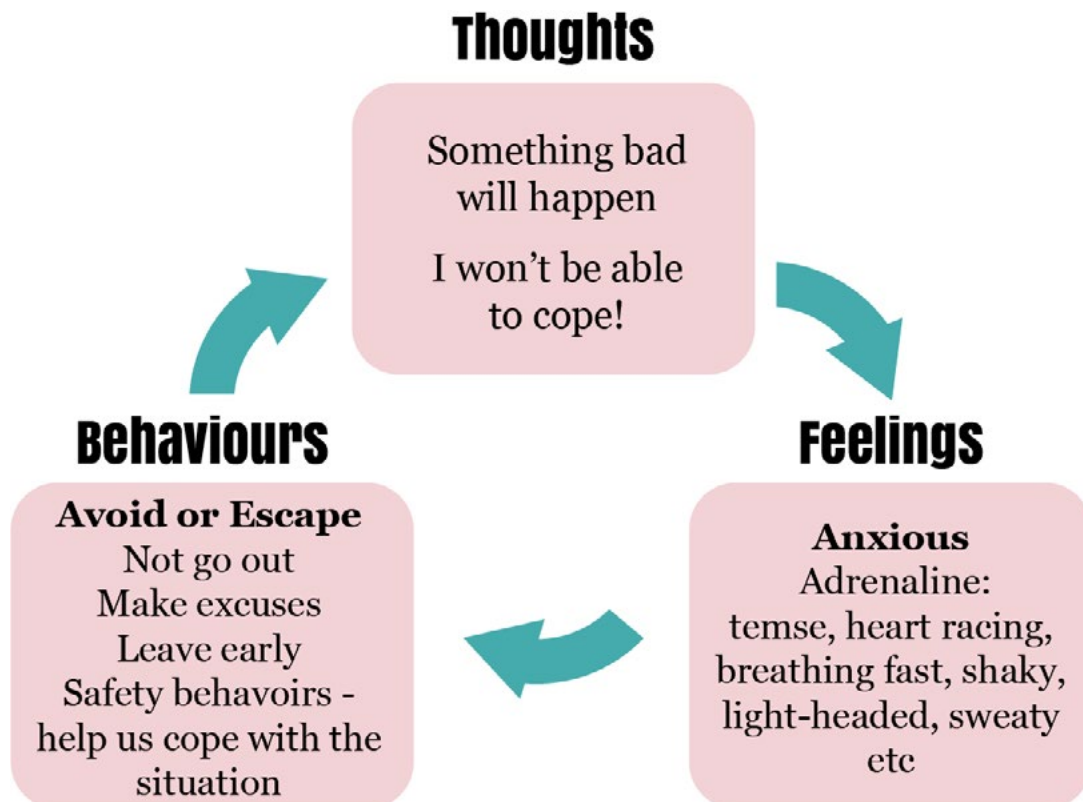
www.lesleyshearer.com

UNDERSTANDING THE ‘TWO CYCLES’ OF PANIC AND ANXIETY

Let's move on to understanding our anxiety and panic a little more now. You may remember the CBT model I have shared elsewhere on here. A **cognitive – behavioural** way of looking at things can really help us to understand those cycles we can get ourselves stuck in. We have a **THOUGHT** about a trigger situation that influences the way we **FEEL** (both physically and emotionally) that leads to the way we **BEHAVE**. Because we learn not to face our trigger situation head on, we get stuck in this nasty cycle and don't recover. YUK!

ANXIETY

Consider the diagram below



Is there a trigger situation in YOUR life we could apply this to?

Maybe going on a date with someone for the first time?

Perhaps you had a dodgy date at the local bowling alley a year or so ago. You panicked so much at the time, you feel that you messed up and that's why your date didn't want to see you again. You got yourself so embarrassed about the whole situation that you didn't even want to go NEAR the bowling alley again. Now you've got another date in a couple of days with someone you really like at the cinema next door to the dreaded bowling alley.

You've been **WORRYING** about having another date for a long while now (ever since the last one!), **THINKING** things like

Something bad will happen

I won't be able to cope....

if you ever went on a date again...

Can you see how this is **ANTICIPATORY** anxiety -worrying about something before it has even happened? Worrying about panic that has not even happened yet?! We've spoken about anticipatory anxiety elsewhere here.

These **THOUGHTS** lead to those **HORRIBLE** feelings....

tense

heart racing

breathing fast

shaky

light headed

sweaty

And so your **BEHAVIOUR** over the past year has been to **AVOID** the bowling alley or anywhere near it! You have even avoided dating altogether! All because you are anxious about the potential of another panic attack!

Avoidance can lead to more severe conditions like agoraphobia where we avoid certain places because of the fear of a panic attack and of not being able to escape, which eventually may keep us from going out at all.

This is powerful and destructive stuff!

PANIC

Panic is anxiety taken to an extreme. As we have discussed elsewhere, anxiety is a completely natural and often a helpful process designed to keep us safe through life. Panic though, is where the normal physical sensations of anxiety are experienced as so DANGEROUS to the individual that they actually believe that their symptoms mean they are going to die.

So in order to deal well with panic, it is important to remember that anxiety is normal and natural. It is NOT something to get rid of! Imagine going through life not feeling a bit hot if you get home to realise that you accidentally left the door unlocked (not safe!) or a heart flutter when you see the person you fancy across the corridor (not fun!!)

We need to be able to feel a little pumped at times!

So the key to managing panic is altering our **UNDERSTANDING** of it.

What leads us from anxiety to panic often lies in the way we **INTERPRET** our original symptoms.

Consider the example from earlier (the date from hell!!)

In the original scenario, you got into a bit of a state on the date at the bowling alley...

Perhaps you stammered asking your date if they wanted a drink...

Perhaps your palms got a bit sweaty and you dropped the bowling ball instead of rolling it slickly down the alley...

Maybe you went to the toilet a couple more times that looked cool...

Now it just so happened that the date didn't work out and you didn't see each other again. But in the days, weeks and months that followed you **COMPLETELY** misinterpreted what went on.

Because you **BELIEVED** that your symptoms **MEANT** something (that your date thought that you were useless), in other words because you **CATASTROPHISED** your symptoms, you got yourself into a new and dangerous cycle – a cycle of panic...

The PANIC CYCLE



You have then gotten yourself into another cycle – one of avoidance. When we **AVOID** we do not give ourselves the opportunity to remind ourselves that those initial feelings of anxiety are natural and normal. We get back into the cycle of anxiety, so much so that the symptoms become familiar and easily triggered in other situations too.

And so the panic is maintained....

So to overcome panic we need to

- UNDERSTAND that anxiety is natural and does not have to mean anything
- CHALLENGE the way we think about our experiences
- LEARN how to break these cycles of fear by putting the above understanding with gentle patience

Below is the **FOUR MAIN CYCLES** in panic

